

FIGURE 3

Officer P’s Journey

This hypothetical scenario draws on real-world experiences shared by law enforcement leaders, along with information from resources and experts on DOJ funding.

Meet Officer P

Officer P is a veteran police officer in a small rural town who sees the same challenges every day: overdoses, behavioral health crises, and homelessness. He knows that jail, the main tool he has at hand, will not help steer people toward sobriety or stable lives.

Through research, he learns about co-responder models, which pair officers with mental health professionals on behavioral health calls. The approach has shown promising results elsewhere, and he hopes it can help his community.

Officer P gets buy-in from his police chief, the mayor’s office, the local clinic, and the community. Some remain skeptical, but they agree that the status quo is not working. The city council approves the pilot program contingent on receiving external funding, such as a grant.

Since the city and state do not have room in their budgets to fund the program, Officer P speaks with his district’s representative in Congress about possible options. His representative points him to JMHCP¹ and other DOJ grant programs that may support initiatives like his.

Appropriations Process

Before Officer P begins searching for grants, the annual appropriations process determines how much funding is available for DOJ grant programs. This process can affect when grant opportunities are announced and whether awards can be made.

1. Agencies submit budget requests to OMB
2. President submits budget request to Congress
3. Congress holds hearings and passes appropriations, which the president signs into law
4. OMB apportions funds to agencies
5. Agencies release NOFOs based on available or anticipated funding

Other Challenges

- Officer P completes much of this work during personal time off the clock and between his regular job responsibilities. His department assigns an admin to help him part time, but much of the workload still falls on him because the grant does not cover dedicated grant management staff.
- He sees funding being terminated mid-grant for programs like his and worries that his program could lose funding after it begins. State and local agencies do not have replacement funds, and his department lacks the bandwidth to pursue private grants or donations.
- Because the grant lasts only three years, Officer P must seek continued funding while still launching and managing the program. He may not yet have enough data to demonstrate results, and reapplying takes time away from implementation.

Changes That Could Help Applicants Like Officer P

- Publish a public annual DOJ program plan before each fiscal year begins
- Post NOFOs on a predictable timeline
- Standardize applications across DOJ grantmaking offices
- Keep application windows open at least 90 days
- Provide funding for grant administration staff support
- Create five-year award periods for selected projects
- Limit midstream grant cancellations after awards are approved

¹ JMHCP: The U.S. Department of Justice’s Justice and Mental Health Collaboration Program, which supports partnerships between criminal justice and mental health agencies.

² NOFO (Notice of Funding Opportunity): The official announcement that describes a federal grant program, including eligibility, application requirements, deadlines, and available funding.

³ UEI (Unique Entity Identifier): A 12-character alphanumeric code assigned by SAM.gov to uniquely identify an entity in federal award systems.

*Timelines are illustrative estimates. Actual timing varies by program and year, and some steps may occur at the same time.

